

BEYOND THE KINGDOM — Series Format Bible

Document 01 · Locked Canon · Format & Production Rules

In-universe "today": Monday, January 3, 2005 (Premiere Day)

1. Locked Facts (Canon — Do Not Change)

Item	Locked Value
Title	Beyond the Kingdom
Format	Daytime soap opera (serial drama), Monday–Friday
Series premiere (in-universe)	Monday, January 3, 2005
Present day	2005 — the story moves forward in real time from here
Setting	A fictional, private, gated luxury community in the affluent Atlanta, Georgia area
Core family	The Donohues — Victor, Joan, Jasmine, Natasha, and Alvin
Family identity	A "powerful and prestigious multigenerational family" — "Black Royalty"
Cast	Primarily African American, with a few non-Black characters
Storytelling tools	Screenplay-format scenes + in-world news/media headlines + 2005-era internet & fan reaction
Deliverables	Every document is also delivered as a PDF

Premise: Set in a fictional gated community in the affluent Atlanta area, *Beyond the Kingdom* tells the story of a wealthy Black family in a posh, gated community. At the center of the story is the Donohue Family — Victor, Joan, Jasmine, Natasha, and Alvin — a powerful and prestigious multigenerational family known as "Black Royalty."

Character bios, birthdays, and backstories arrive in the next document (Document 02 — Character Bible).

2. Episodes Per Year — 250

Answer: 250 new episodes per year.

- A real daytime soap airs every weekday — about 260 airdates per year.
- In 2005 there are 255 weekday airdates after the usual holiday preemptions (Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving, and the Christmas observance).

- Taking out about 5 more days for real-world preemptions (breaking news, sports, presidential addresses) leaves **250**. That is the real network daytime standard for a one-hour soap.
 - Every broadcast week is 5 episodes, and the story moves on each weekday.
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3. Season Numbering — The Broadcast-Season Model

Answer: Number seasons by the U.S. broadcast TV season, which runs from mid-September to mid-September. Number episodes cumulatively and never reset them.

Real daytime soaps work this way. They don't restart at "Episode 1" each season. The episode counter runs continuously (for example, *Episode #5,000*), and "seasons" are industry bookkeeping tied to the fall broadcast season. A soap that premieres mid-season (like ours, in January) has a shortened first season.

Season	Broadcast Window	Airdate Slots	New Episodes	Episode Numbers
Season 1 (Premiere Season)	Mon Jan 3, 2005 – Fri Sep 16, 2005	182	180	#0001 – #0180
Season 2	Mon Sep 19, 2005 – Fri Sep 15, 2006	254	250	#0181 – #0430
Season 3 and beyond	Mid-September to mid-September	~255	250	Continues cumulatively

How to reference an episode: *Season 1 · Episode #0001 · Monday, January 3, 2005*

Holidays with no new episode in Season 1: Memorial Day (Mon May 30, 2005), Independence Day (Mon Jul 4, 2005), Labor Day (Mon Sep 5, 2005). Two more Season 1 dates are held for real-world preemptions.

Sweeps periods (ratings months — the biggest cliffhangers, weddings, deaths, and reveals land here):

- February 2005 sweeps: about Feb 3 – Mar 2, 2005
 - May 2005 sweeps: about Apr 28 – May 25, 2005
 - November 2005 sweeps: about Oct 27 – Nov 23, 2005
 - **Season finale:** Friday, September 16, 2005 — the biggest Friday cliffhanger of the year
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4. Serialized vs. Standalone — 95% / 5%

Answer: 95% serialized, 5% standalone.

- **95% serialized:** Every episode continues the storylines from the day before. Storylines overlap, pick up where they left off, and pay off weeks or months later. This is the real daytime formula.

- **5% "standalone-feel" specials:** About 12–13 episodes a year. They still count in continuity, but each one centers on a single event or format:
- Holiday episodes (Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Year's Eve)
- Flashback / "family history" episodes about the Donohue legacy
- A wedding, funeral, or gala shown across one full hour
- "Two-hander" episodes (a single long confrontation between two characters)
- Anniversary episodes
- **Continuity rule:** Nothing is ever "reset." Every event, injury, secret, marriage, birth, death, and lie is permanent canon unless the story itself changes it (a reveal, a lie exposed, a return).

Continuity Protocol

- 1 **Master Timeline Log:** Every scene carries a date and time stamp.
 - 2 **Age Tracker:** Ages are calculated from locked birthdays and change on each birthday. A character's age on any date is always exact.
 - 3 **No SORAS without an on-screen reason.** ("Soap Opera Rapid Aging" is a common soap trick. We avoid it to keep it real.)
 - 4 **Story Ledger:** An ongoing list of open secrets (who knows what, and since when).
 - 5 **Relationship Map:** Marriages, divorces, affairs, and paternity, all dated.
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5. Genre, Subgenres, Rating & Runtime

Category	Answer
Primary Genre	Daytime Soap Opera / Serial Drama
Subgenres	Family saga · Dynasty/wealth drama · Romantic melodrama · Corporate & political power drama · Mystery/suspense · Legal drama · Crime thriller
Themes	Legacy, power, loyalty, betrayal, secrets, class within the Black elite, faith, ambition, love
Tone	Glamorous, high-stakes, emotional, realistic — "Black Royalty" behind the gates
Rating	TV-14 (D, L, S, V) — suggestive dialogue, strong language, sexual situations, violence (within daytime network standards)
Timeslot	One-hour weekday broadcast (e.g., 1:00–2:00 PM ET)
Runtime	60-minute slot · about 42 minutes of story (2005 network daytime hours ran about 18 minutes of commercials, promos, and credits)

6. Episode Titles

Answer: Real daytime soaps don't give episodes titles. Each episode is identified by its **episode number + air date**, plus an internal **production number**.

Official format:

BEYOND THE KINGDOM — Episode #0001

Air Date: Monday, January 3, 2005

Prod. #BTK-0001

Special exception: Landmark episodes get an in-world promo "event name" for press, ads, and fans. Examples:

- "The Premiere" (Ep #0001)
- "The Donohue Gala" (a sweeps event)
- "The 100th Episode" (Ep #0100)
- "Season Finale" (Ep #0180)

These names appear only in marketing, soap-magazine headlines, and fan chatter. They never replace the number and date.

7. Script Length, Acts & Scenes

Element	Standard
Script length	75–90 pages (target: 80 pages) for a one-hour daytime episode. Daytime scripts are dialogue-heavy and multi-camera, so they run longer than a primetime hour.
Structure	Teaser (Cold Open) + 6 Acts
Scenes	24–30 scenes per episode (target: 28)
Storylines per episode	3–5 storylines rotated through the acts
Scenes per act	Teaser: 1–2 · Acts 1–6: 4–5 each
Act breaks	Every act ends on a "hook" (a reveal, a slap, a stare, a doorbell). Act 6 ends on the day's cliffhanger.
Friday rule	The Friday cliffhanger is the biggest of the week. It keeps the audience coming back Monday.

Episode Template

- 1 **Title Card:** Episode #, air date, production #, in-universe dates covered
- 2 **TEASER (Cold Open):** Picks up exactly where the last episode ended
- 3 **Main Title Sequence**
- 4 **ACT ONE – ACT SIX:** Scenes rotate between storylines
- 5 **Cliffhanger Tag**

6 "Next on Beyond the Kingdom" preview

7 Media & Fan Layer: News headlines, press, and fan posts reacting to that episode's events

Screenplay Scene Format

INT. [LOCATION] - [DAY/NIGHT]
[Day, Month Date, 2005 – Time]

[Action lines in present tense.]

CHARACTER NAME (age)
(parenthetical)
Dialogue.

8. Storytelling Layers (2005 Period Accuracy)

The story is told through three layers:

A. Screenplay Scenes — character-driven dialogue that drives the drama.

B. News & Media (2005 outlets and formats)

- Local Atlanta print and TV news, business pages, society columns, and gossip columns
- National Black media (magazines, cable entertainment news, radio)
- Business press for Donohue corporate storylines
- Soap magazine coverage (weekly soap digests, covers, spoilers)

C. The Internet & Fans — only what existed in 2005

- **Available in 2005:** Soap message boards and forums, AOL, email chains, fan sites, LiveJournal, Xanga, BlackPlanet, MySpace, Blogger/blogs, text messaging (SMS), two-way pagers/Sidekicks/BlackBerrys, flip phones (e.g., Motorola RAZR)
 - **Facebook:** Limited to college students in 2005
 - **YouTube:** Launches in 2005 (public beta in spring). Not usable in January 2005.
 - **Not yet available — never use in 2005 scenes:** Twitter (2006), iPhone (2007), Instagram (2010), smartphone apps, hashtags as a trend culture, streaming services
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9. Timeline & Age Rules

- Every scene carries an **in-universe date and time** (e.g., *Monday, January 3, 2005 — 7:42 PM EST*).
- Atlanta is in **Eastern Time**. EST applies until DST begins on **Sunday, April 3, 2005**, then EDT until **Sunday, October 30, 2005**.

- **Ages are calculated from each character's exact birthday.** A character born June 10, 1950 is **54** on January 3, 2005 and turns **55** on June 10, 2005.
 - Birthdays are on-screen events when they matter to the story.
 - One airdate usually covers one story day. Timelines can compress (several episodes covering one gala night) or skip (a time jump announced on screen).
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10. Quick Reference Summary

Question	Answer
Episodes per year	250 (5 per week, Mon–Fri)
Season numbering	Broadcast season (Sep–Sep); cumulative episode numbers. Season 1 = Jan 3 – Sep 16, 2005 (Eps #0001–#0180)
Serialized / Standalone	95% / 5%
Genre	Daytime Soap Opera / Serial Drama
Subgenres	Family saga, dynasty drama, romance, corporate/political drama, mystery, legal, crime
Rating	TV-14 (D, L, S, V)
Runtime	60-min slot / about 42 minutes of story
Episode titles	Episode # + air date + production # (event names for landmark episodes only)
Script length	75–90 pages (target 80)
Acts	Teaser + 6 Acts
Scenes	24–30 (target 28)

Next: Document 02 — Character Bible (to be provided by the creator).